

Naked mole rat

No other mammal has a life cycle quite like that of the naked mole rat. These burrowing rodents live in large groups, or colonies, underground that are run kind of like bees in a beehive. One dominant female—the queen—produces all the babies.

Powerful queen

The biggest, most aggressive member of the colony is the queen. Her presence alone is enough to stop other colony members from breeding. She can keep producing babies for 16 years—a long time for such a small rodent.

One captive female produced more than 900 babies in just 11 years.

Roots and tubers provide all the food and water that the colony needs.

Workers moving into the queen's chamber huddle with babies to keep them warm.

Lots of babies

The queen produces bigger litters than almost any other kind of mammal. Every 12 to 19 weeks she gives birth to up to 28 babies.

A baby naked mole rat leaving the nest.

Moles Mole rats are vegetarian rodents, while moles are worm-eating burrowers. They are fiercely territorial and live alone. Males and females come together only briefly to mate.



Meerkat families

Meerkats live in underground colonies, where a dominant pair produces the babies. Other colony members help with babysitting.

